

Devils Crag #1 and Wheel Mountain

August 13th to 15th, 2011

Out of South Lake above Bishop, CA

Climbing Partners: Jen Blackie

Full Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157627323934911/>

GPS Track: http://farm7.static.flickr.com/6071/6048641907_14ee91cd63_o.jpg

I've been on a roll this summer as far as challenging trips.

This weekend was originally to be a quick two day trip to the Sierra to join Bob Burd and company on the day-hike-a-thon Sierra Challenge. The long hard days would have served as a warm-up for the Kaweah trip starting the following weekend but I couldn't spare the vacation days to do the entire 10 days.

I changed my mind last minute. With only two days there would hardly be time to acclimate and the early part of the challenge is always the furthest north.

Instead I got the idea to go grab Devils Crag.

Devils Crag has quite the reputation among the Sierra climbing community. This is helped in no small part by the fact two experienced mountaineers have died on the mountain in recent memory.

The account of David Dykeman's death can be found here in the 1997 Accidents in North American Mountaineering

http://books.google.com/books?id=bZ763n_CgtcC&lpg=PA28&ots=oEpaB38hSC&dq=Dave%20Dykeman%20devils%20crag&pg=PA28#v=onepage&q&f=false

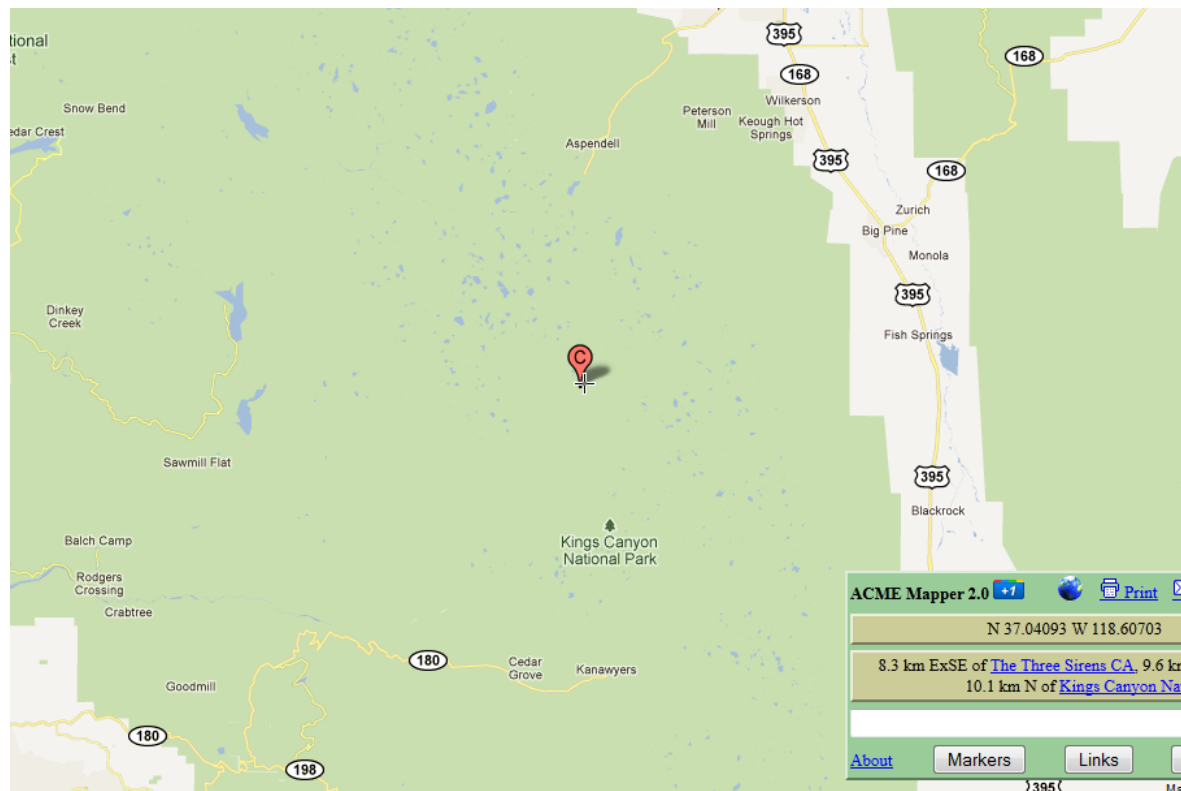
Basically we don't know exactly what happened but assume the rock he was on just gave way.

The other fatality was Mark Hoffman which is discussed in the book The Last Season by Eric Blehm.

The mountain has a reputation for being exposed and loose to the point several SPS'ers have recently hired guides to take them up. As always when I hear stories like this I was anxious to get up there and see for myself.

Jen Blackie was back from her two month Philippines climbing vacation and eagerly agreed to join me.

Part of the difficulty with Devils Crag is that it's along the Black Divide which is rather far in.



The shortest route is from the east entering at South Lake above Bishop and is about 37 miles and over 10k gain round trip. So we'd be doing a hard haul in on little sleep, climbing day two, then a hard haul out and driving home so I could fly back to Boise. Life is good.

Also, due to the snow sticking around longer than usual this year it's been rather hard to get last minute permit reservations since it pushed all the usual early season trips back. As a result we had to get a walk in permit.

For each trailhead there is a certain quota which specifies how many people are allowed to head down the trail each day. Some of these you can reserve ahead of time which is how I do most of my trips) and they save a certain percentage for walk-ins and release them at 11 am the previous morning.

That meant I'd ideally be there at 11 am Friday morning to get a permit for Saturday. As my plane wasn't even landing until 5 pm Friday in Orange County that obviously wasn't going to happen. So we did the best we could and planned to be at the Bishop Ranger station at 8 am just as they opened.

This meant we were going to get a much later start than I would have preferred.

Day 1: Well That's A Late Start



We got there about 7:45 am and found a line already formed. 30 minutes later we had the last two slots of Bishop Pass. Close!



Even better the South Lake trailhead parking was all full so that left us parking two miles down the road at Parchers Resort and walking up the road. Fortunately we had two guys we already knew from the permit line stop and give us a ride.

We finally set off down the trail at 10 am.





Bishop Pass is known as one of the easier passes in the Sierra and so gets a lot of traffic. There are a number of lakes on the way up with numerous camping opportunities for those who don't want to go on over.



The bump in the middle of the picture is Chocolate Peak, a popular easy WTC experience trip. I tried to convince Jen to run up it with me but she wasn't feeling it.



Eventually you leave the lakes and vegetation and start up a rather rocky slope to the pass itself.



There you find this rather dramatic sign:



The pass tops out right below 12k and we made it up at a decent clip. The weather was just spectacular.



We took a moment to strike a victory pose.



Of course now we had to descend back down to 8k and then climb back up to 10k.

So we crossed Dusy Basin which is a gentle descent on a clear trail.



Then descended into LeConte Canyon



It's extremely pretty but one hell of a drop.



Once we were down the endless switchbacks we were in the nicely shaded canyon.



And then met up with the JMT.



We took a bit to poke around the LeConte Ranger Station.





No one was home but we had heard a rumor the ranger was coming up the trail behind us. They actually had a rather neat setup in there with firewood, an outhouse, and lots of signs trying to dissuade anyone from breaking in and stealing their stuff.



Now we had a few miles heading south along the JMT. We ran into a number of thru hikers but most seemed to be settling in to camp for the night.

This was going to be the last section of trail for a while as we would split off, cross the Middle Fork of the Kings, and climb up Rambaud Canyon.



Grouse Meadow. (Not pictured is the naked lady taking a bath off to one side. Hence why I referred to this as Naked Lady Meadow for the remainder of the trip.)



While not quite as spectacular as my Big Pine trip the flowers were still in full bloom due to all the snow melt.

The Middle Fork was running quite swiftly but we managed to find a few precarious logs to get across it.





I actually had a near disaster here. When crossing a somewhat unstable log it shifted and as I went down I saw my camera fly out of the little carry pouch I have attached to my pack. I made a desperate grab, missed, and watched it fall between the logs into the water.

Disaster! No camera! Might as well just turn around now!

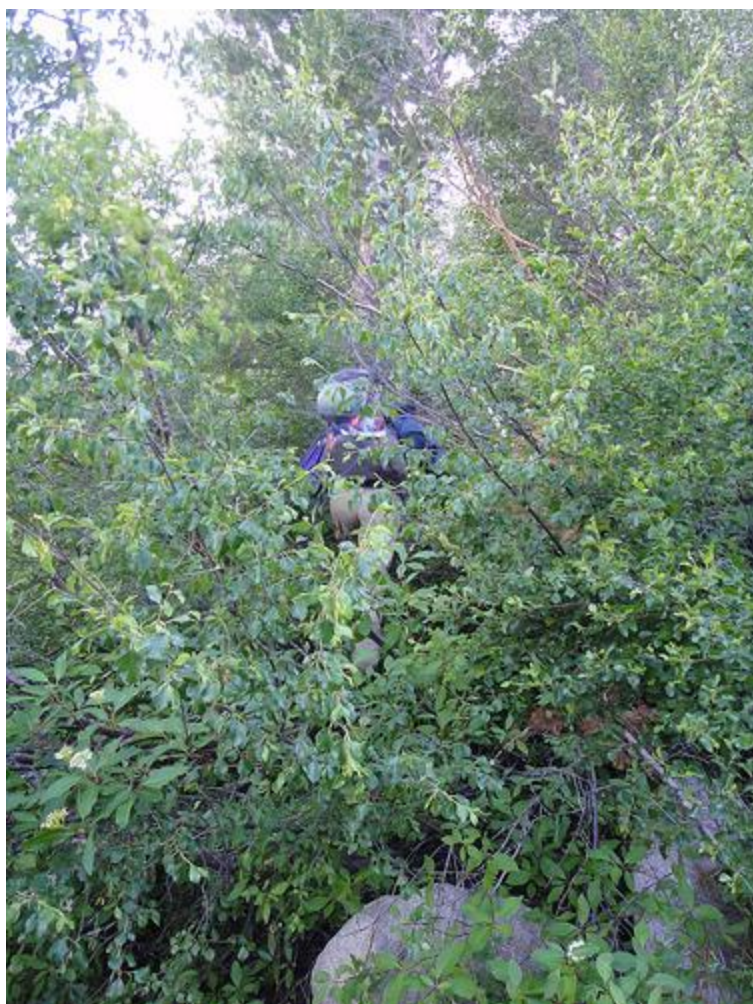
Fortunately the camera was actually just sitting on the bottom under maybe a foot of water and I was able to retrieve it. Despite several dents (that were totally not my fault) it is apparently still fairly water proof and seemed to have survived without major mishap.

Whew! The trip could continue.

From here we traverse a bit further, crossed Rambaud Creek (which was very minor) and started climbing Rambaud Canyon.



And we had a bit of bushwhacking.





The mosquitoes were so bad I pulled out my DEET but even that wasn't enough to keep them away. You have to love when the bugs are biting through the deadly chemicals that come with dire warnings not spray them on children because they'll melt.



We reached a bit under 10k and we were both ready to stop. We ended up swinging off to the left of the canyon a bit and found a small patch of dirt just about big enough for my tent. Well, except for the some surprisingly large rocks sticking up in the middle that took a good 20 minutes to dig out much to Jen's amusement.



I was inside the tent the moment it was up to great relief though it took a while to track down and kill all the mosquitoes that had followed me in. Both of us slept rather well that night.

Day 2: Summit-H0000000000!



We were up at dawn and went about getting ready. Sadly the moment I was out of my tent the mosquito net went on.



From where we camped we had to traverse to the north west a bit to rejoin the main drainage of Rambaud Creek.



Once we did the going was much faster.



We swung around to the south west and passed the higher lakes (which in my original plan we were to camp at) It was rather cold up here and I never found any decent campsites.



Above here we still had a surprising amount of snow.



We had our ice axes but no crampons and both of us were wearing squishy boots. We took our time and used the sun cups to cross the still icy snow.

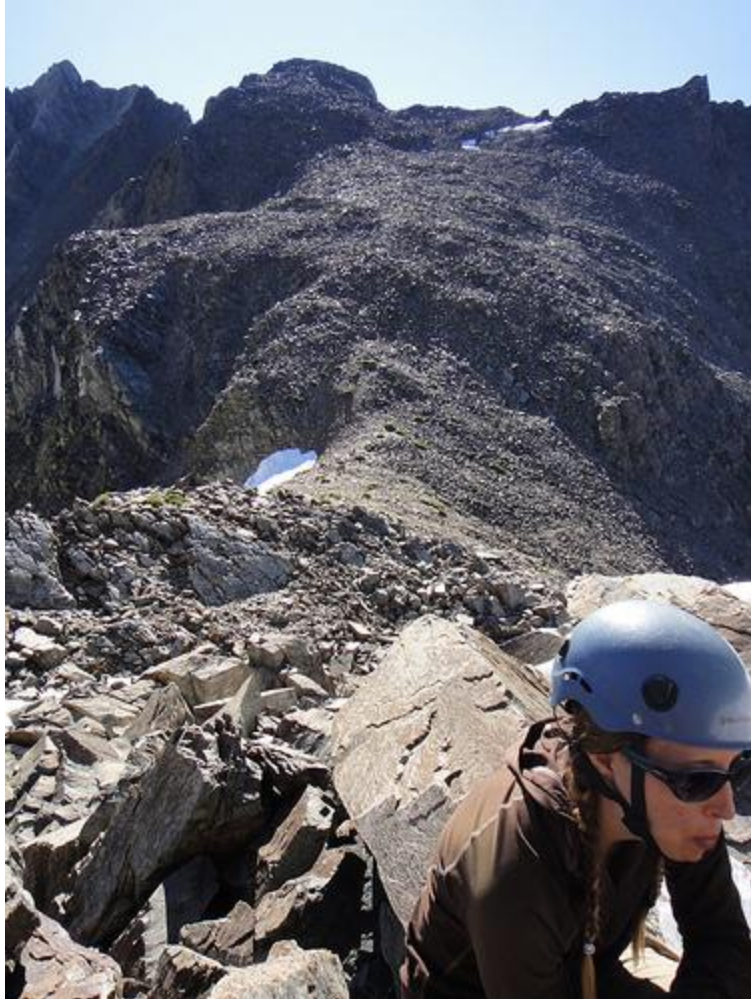
The last climb up to the pass was the worst part and we had to spend a bit of time cutting steps.



But soon we were up top.



The trip reports we had mostly talked about coming up from the opposite side. Looking down we could see why. While the approach is longer it had ideal camping and an easy slope up to the pass. But then again, who wants to do things the easy way?



The approach was fairly obvious. We initially had one of the trip reports out but after descending a short ways and cliffing out we ignored the guides and just went up along the ridge. This worked much better.



And there is Devils Crag #1. You stick right along the ridge and climb straight up. It's a series of 3rd class sections punctuated by 4th class walls and most of the time a fall to either side would be fatal. So falling isn't recommended.



But having said that it was an awesome climb! Far from the loose rock I'd been warned about it was solid and a lot of fun to climb. There were one or two places on the 4th class bits that we really had to take care but we never felt the need to use the rope going up.







Here Jen is just passing the Black Bunny Ears, a landmark early on in the climb.



The 4th class bits did get a little airy here and there.







Again the weather was spectacular and we had great views to either side when we weren't completely focused on the rock. (Which was most of the time)



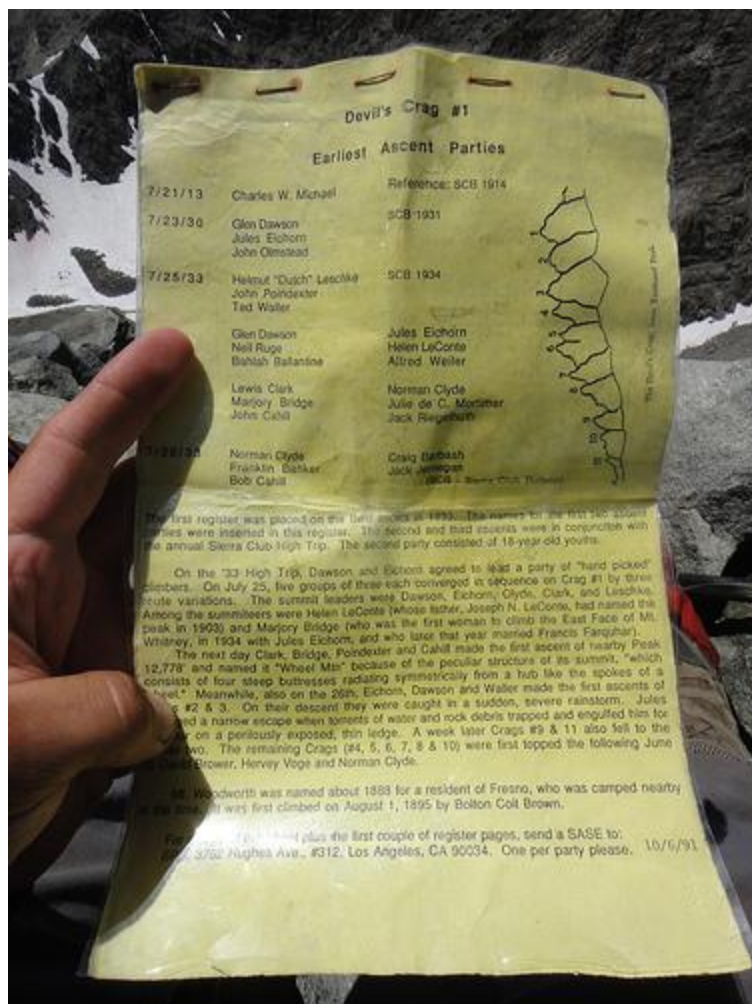


The last section was actually described as the crux by some of the write-ups. It's an exposed bit of 3rd class ridge that drops off to either side rather abruptly. We crossed it rather easily and

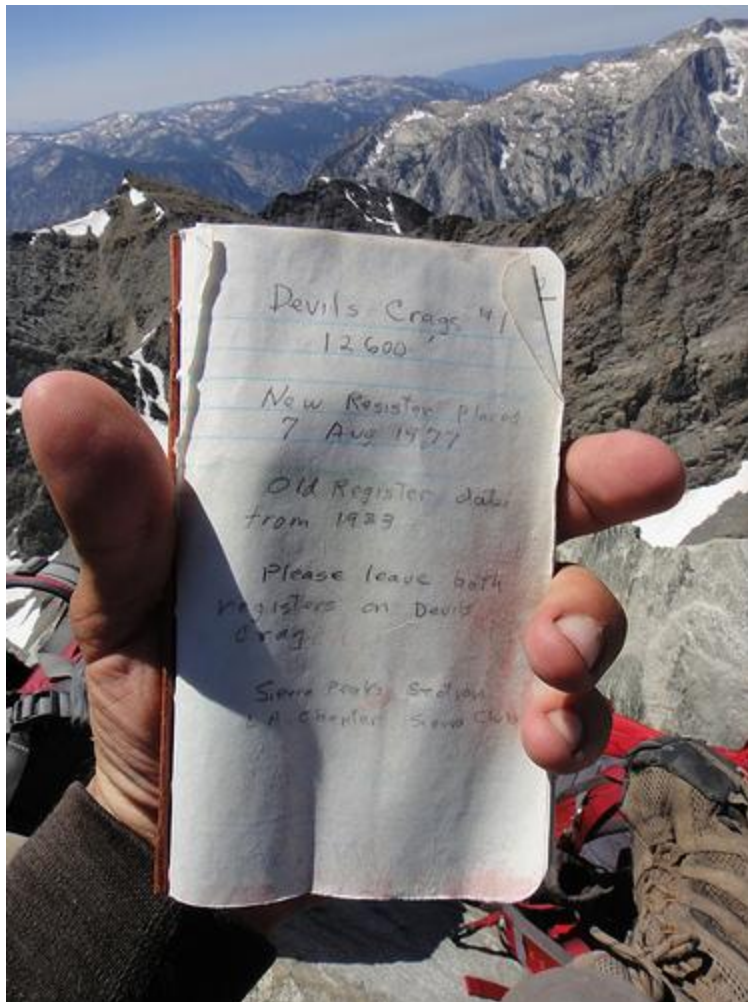
both were surprised at the description. Granted protecting it with a rope would have been somewhat challenging.



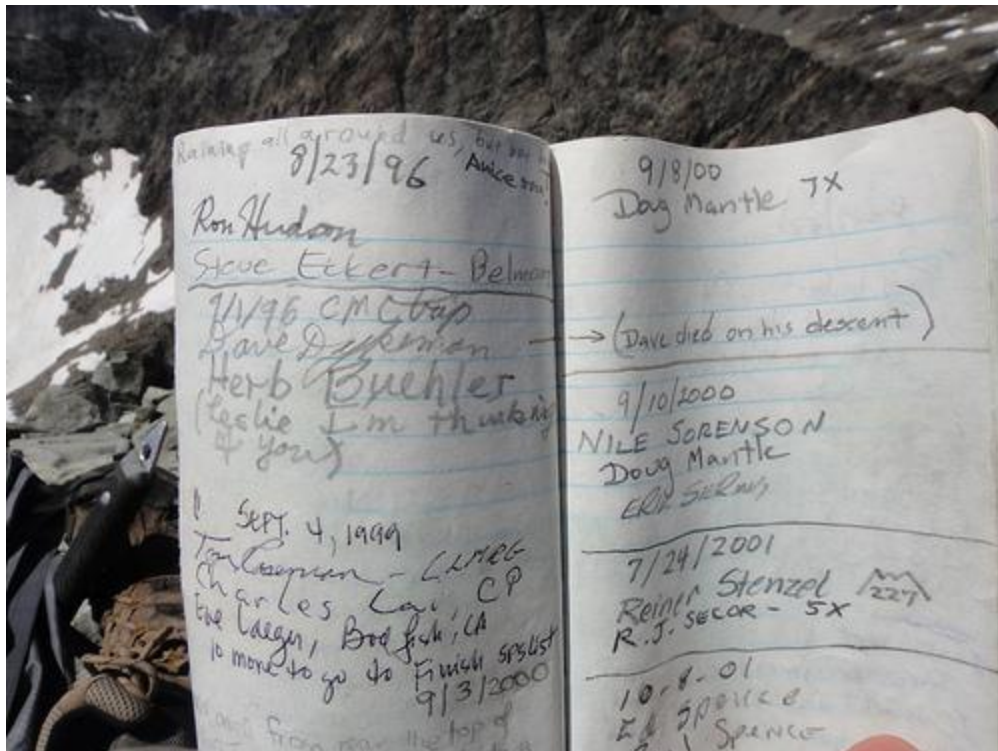
We topped out and found our register. It had lived a rather rough life.



The original register had been removed years ago and in its place was a replica. Bit of a bummer as the early sign-ins had some rather big names.



The current register was from '77 and had maybe 10 pages filled.



In addition to seeing a number of friends we found Dave Dykman's signature. And Doug Mantle's numerous sign-ins.



We took a bit to admire the view.



Now we just had to get back down.



Also the darker peak in the background is Wheel, also an SPS peak. I had hopes of grabbing that before we went down but I was somewhat worried about descending the snow slope into Ranbaud Canyon after dark as it was likely to ice back up.



Most of the ridge was just downclimbing but the 4th class sections we (carefully) rappelled down.



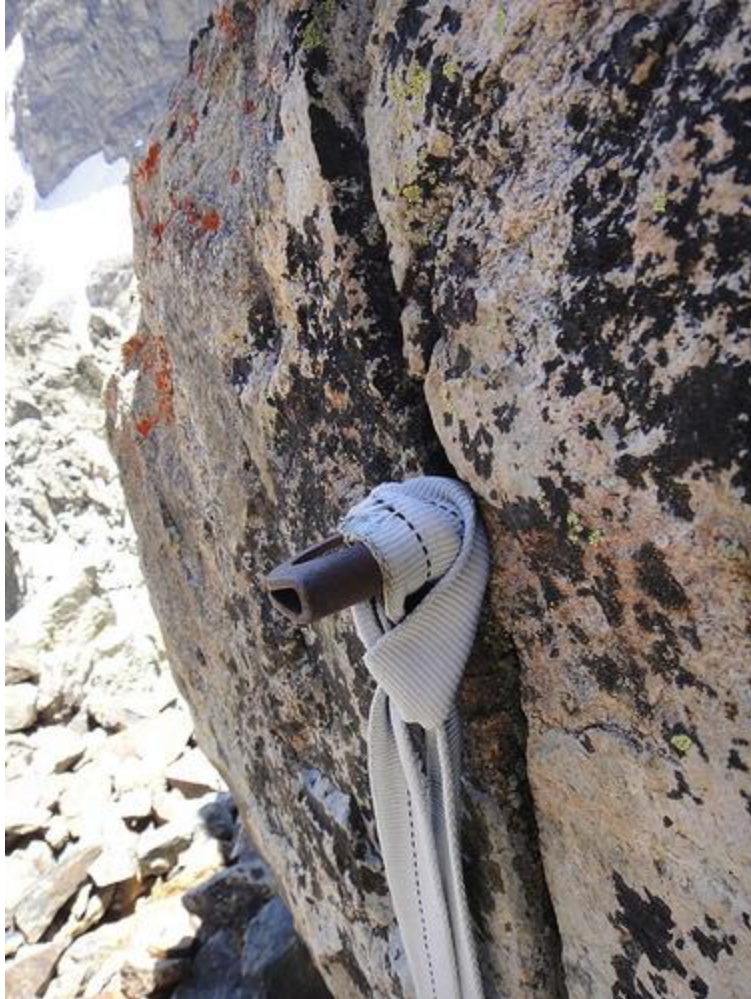


There were existing rap stations like the one above at every 4th class pitch but a few were rotting away. We ended up reinforcing a few and pulling some old webbing which was badly frayed.





Near the bottom we dropped down a little too low and came across some old pitons.



If you see this you're off route. If you rappelled off it I have no clue where you were going...



Looking back we had a nice view of the Crag.

We were tired but decided to press on to Wheel. What's another thousand feet or so?

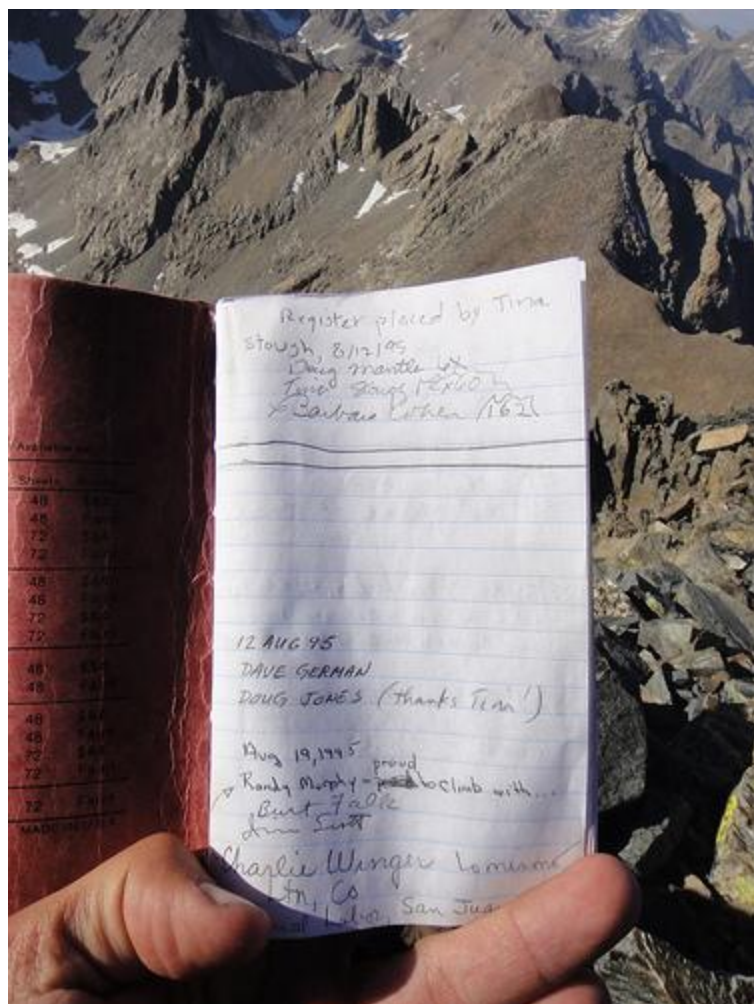


It hurt. Both of us were forcing ourselves to march up the rather dull slopes feeling the altitude much more than I thought we should be.

The climb was trivial but near the top we passed through a series of towering rocks that were rather neat.



And found another register, this one from 1995.



Register placed by Tina
Stough, 8/12/95
Doug Mantle LX
Dave Jones LX
Barbara Parker MBZ

12 AUG 95

DAVE GERMAN

DOUG JONES (thanks Tina!)

Aug 19, 1995

Randy Murphy - proud to climb with...

Burt Falc

Jim Surt

Charlie Wanger Lomax

Ln, Co

Ln, San Jua





Now we had to hurry down to take advantage of the light we had left.



Devils Crag looked even more spectacular from this angle. The prominent ridge is the route we used.



The descent back to Rambaud was doable as we ended up avoiding the snow and easing our way down some rather nasty loose rock.



Very loose.



Once down we just had a few hours to get back to camp. It was dusk as we passed the upper lakes and we spent a bit of time watching bats darting over the top of the water presumably catching insects. I decided I wanted a bat box on the top of my tent to keep down the bugs.



When the moon came up over the far ridge it was an awesome sight that of course just can't be captured on a camera.



We made it back to camp sometime around 10 pm, ate a quick dinner, and went to sleep tired but happy.

Day 3: Do We Have To?

We'd made both our peaks and now just had to hike all the way back out, drive home, and get me on a plane by 6:45 am the following morning. Bleh.

We had a long hike out but I was loath to hurry out of such a pretty place. Instead I delayed us a bit to enjoy a cup of coffee much to Jen's quiet consternation.





The descent down Rambaud was pretty much as bad as the climb. Nothing approaching a use trail exists since few people climb it.





Crossing back over the Kings proved to be a bit more challenging and we would have been better off just using the same precarious logs we crossed the first time. As soon as we were across and back on the JTM the going was much quicker.



Of course we had to climb from 7+k to 12k with the big hump being getting out of LeConte and back up in to Dusy Basin.



Along the way we actually ran into the LeConte rangers, Randy Sanger and his wife. Randy is somewhat famous for some children's books he's written and he's also mentioned rather extensively in *The Last Season*.



We chatted with them and another couple for quite a while. No one could quite believe the Boise -> OC -> Sierra -> OC -> Boise commute.

Interesting enough one person had actually done two failed attempts on Black Kaweah and described the rock as "climbing a library." Jen and I were headed for the Kaweahs next week so I was curious to see if Black was exaggerated like Devil's Crag.



The climb up was warm but there's a nice spot by a waterfall partway up.





A large group of Asian backpackers showed up while we were there taking a lot of pictures. They all seemed nice enough though the guy running the group was a bit of an oddball.





Dusy Basin wasn't much more interesting in this direction.



We did run into two mule trains on their way in though we didn't get much of a chance to chat with them.



And finally we were back on Bishop Pass with the rest of the hike out being all downhill.

And here we ran into something I'd never seen before...



A group of aussies carrying kayaks plus camping gear headed for LeConte Canyon to put in.



Apparently the boats plus gear were about 80 pounds. Jen and I both felt slightly foolish for grumbling about our own packs.



I chatted with a few but they were obviously set on making it up and over the pass. They intended to camp in Dusy Basin and hit the river the following day for a few days worth of paddling downstream.



Stopping once we were over the pass was kept to a minimum as the mosquitoes were out in force. We kept on and after what felt like a good long time made it back to the trailhead.



And now of course we had to walk the road for 2 miles to get back to my vehicle



I attempted to hitchhike only to be passed by the first few vehicles though I did get waved at by a mean old lady in a truck. We walked passed an RV only to have them go inside the shut the door. We must have looked a bit ragged.



Well, at least by boots were.

We made it back to the car and headed into town for post hike Mexican food which is even better than pre hike Mexican food or any other day Mexican food though it's hard to go wrong with any of those.



And while driving home we came across this oddness in Mojave.



(Mojave is weird enough without escape clowns running around)

We made it home late and I was off to Boise for 4 days after which we were headed to the west side for the big 9 day Kaweah Peak Bagging Jamboree.

That would be the trip where I'd take a fall on day 6 and require a SAR evac. Coming Soon!